SECURITY IRELAND NOTE

Energy Security as the Sixth Domain

Ireland's fuel crisis reveals the same architectural absence the foundational papers diagnose in maritime, airspace, subsea, cyber, and intelligence. A state configured for the absence of security capability is discovering what that absence means when the supply chain that invisibly sustained it is disrupted.

Security Ireland

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IN BRIEF

Ireland imports 100 per cent of its oil, and it has no refining capacity since the Whitegate refinery ceased independent operation. Its strategic reserve—managed by NORA—holds 90 days of supply, of which 28 per cent is stored abroad. Ireland has already released 1.6 million barrels (10.5 days of supply) to the IEA collective action.

The institutional architecture for fuel crisis management rests on the 1971 Fuels (Control of Supplies) Act—legislation written before Ireland joined the EEC, before the first oil crisis, and before the internet. The contingency plan involves Defence Forces at petrol station forecourts checking workers' identification. This is the energy domain version of the Zelensky drone incident: a state without institutional infrastructure for crisis response reaching for the only coercive tools it has.

The five security domains analysed in the foundational papers—maritime, airspace, subsea, energy grid, cyber—missed the sixth. Fuel supply is not the electricity grid; it is a separate vulnerability with a separate institutional architecture—or rather, the absence of one. This note identifies the gap and proposes six reforms that can be initiated immediately.

What is happening

The US–Israel war on Iran, which began in mid-March 2026, has disrupted global oil markets. Brent crude has surged from approximately $65 to above $100 per barrel. The Strait of Hormuz—through which roughly a fifth of global oil and gas flows—is effectively disrupted. The Houthis are threatening to close the Bab el-Mandeb strait, which would cut the alternative Red Sea shipping route. The thirty-two IEA member countries have agreed to release 400 million barrels from strategic reserves—the largest coordinated release since the system was created in 1974.

In Ireland, diesel prices have risen from approximately €1.80 to above €2.20 per litre. Home heating oil has nearly doubled, from approximately €500 to close to €900 for 500 litres. Agricultural diesel—on which the farming sector depends—has risen proportionally. The government has responded with a €250 million package: excise duty cuts of 20 cent on diesel and 15 cent on petrol, suspension of the 2 cent NORA levy, a diesel rebate scheme for hauliers backdated to January, and an extension of the fuel allowance to €76 per week for 470,000 recipients. A new cross-government taskforce has been established to fast-track renewable energy.

Behind the public measures, the government is stress-testing contingency plans that include fuel rationing, Defence Forces and Gardaí stationed at garage forecourts to check workers' identification, mandatory remote working for non-essential workers, strict speed limit reductions, and limits on the amount of fuel motorists can purchase. The Taoiseach has stated the government is 'not contemplating' rationing at this stage—but the contingency plans exist because the institutional architecture for managing a prolonged supply disruption does not.

The double dependency: oil and gas

The oil crisis has obscured a parallel vulnerability that may prove more consequential: natural gas. Ireland imports approximately 80 per cent of its natural gas via two subsea interconnectors from Great Britain. The remaining 20 per cent comes from the Corrib gas field off the west coast of Mayo—but Corrib production is in terminal decline and is expected to cease entirely by 2027. When Corrib depletes, Ireland will be 100 per cent dependent on gas imports through a single route: the interconnectors from Scotland.

Natural gas provides approximately 30 per cent of Ireland's total primary energy requirement. It generates over 50 per cent of Ireland's electricity. It heats 650,000 households. It is the primary dispatchable fuel backing up intermittent renewables (wind and solar) on the electricity grid. The Celtic Interconnector to France, arriving in 2027, helps stabilise the electricity market—but gas remains the fuel that keeps the lights on when the wind stops blowing.

Ireland has no LNG terminal. It has no gas storage—the only EU member state without any. The Kinsale gas field off Cork, which supplied all of Ireland's gas from 1978 to 1995, is depleted and closed. The government approved a Floating Storage and Regasification Unit (FSRU) in March 2025 as a strategic gas emergency reserve—a specialised ship that stores liquefied natural gas and converts it to gas when needed. But the FSRU is not yet operational, and its capacity (enough to supply approximately 200,000 households for six months) is a fraction of national demand.

The double dependency is therefore: 100 per cent oil import dependence with no refining capacity, and approaching 100 per cent gas import dependence through a single pipeline route with no storage and no LNG terminal. Both are exposed to the same geopolitical disruption. A prolonged closure of the Strait of Hormuz does not merely raise fuel prices—it threatens the electricity supply that the entire economy depends on, because the gas that generates half of Ireland's electricity flows through supply chains disrupted by the same conflict.

> ***Ireland is possibly the least flexible country in Europe to adapt to any energy supply disruption: no LNG terminal, no gas storage, no nuclear power, no refining capacity, and a single pipeline route for gas imports.***

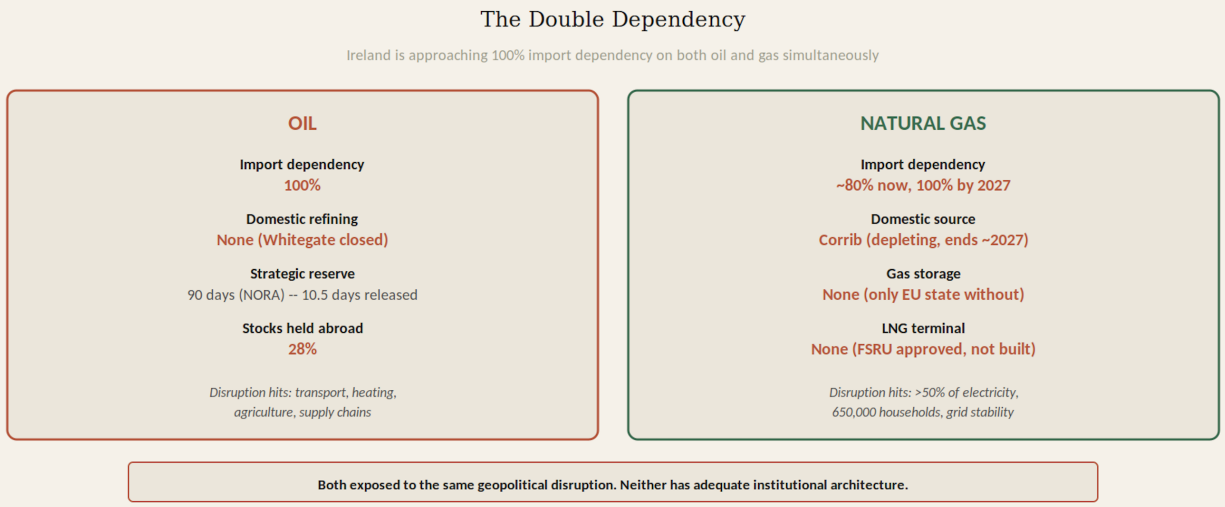

Figure 2: The double dependency. Ireland is approaching 100% import dependency on both oil and gas simultaneously. Neither has adequate institutional architecture. Both are exposed to the same geopolitical disruption.

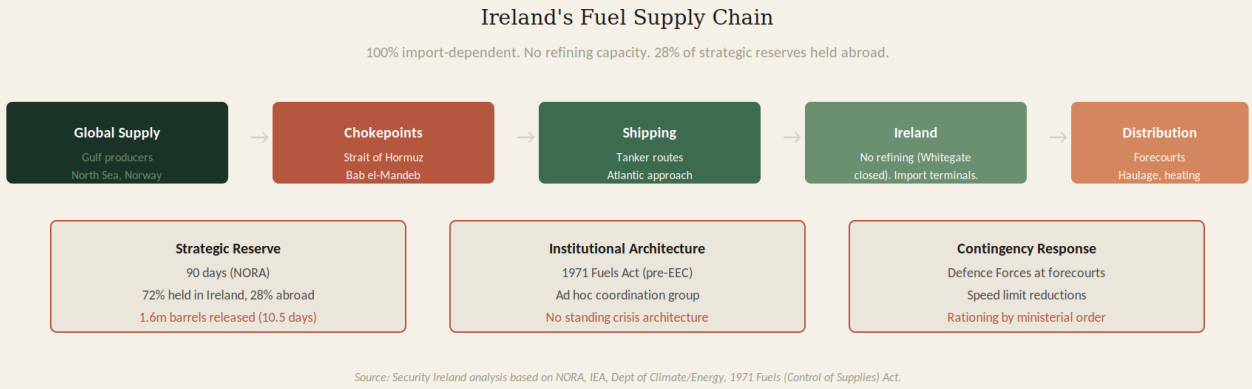

Figure 1: Ireland's fuel supply chain. 100% import-dependent with no refining capacity. The strategic reserve holds 90 days of supply but 28% is stored abroad. Ireland has already released 10.5 days of supply to the IEA collective action.

The institutional gap

Ireland's fuel security architecture rests on three pillars, each of which is inadequate for the crisis it now faces.

The legal framework is obsolete. The 1971 Fuels (Control of Supplies) Act, as amended in 1982, provides the legal basis for government intervention in fuel markets. The Act gives the Minister power to "take control of the supply and distribution of fuels" by government order. This is a blunt instrument—designed for an era of state-owned fuel companies and physical supply rationing—applied to a liberalised, internationally integrated energy market with complex supply chains, hedging practices, and just-in-time distribution. The Act does not address cyber threats to fuel infrastructure, hybrid disruption of shipping routes, or the coordination of cross-border fuel supply with Northern Ireland.

The institutional architecture is ad hoc. Fuel security coordination is fragmented across four departments. The Department of Climate, Energy and the Environment manages NORA and convenes the Oil Security of Supply Group. The Department of Transport manages haulage and speed limits. The Department of Defence provides enforcement personnel. The Department of Justice manages public order. In a prolonged crisis, the National Emergency Coordination Group—comprising representatives of all departments, agencies, and industry—would be convened. But this is an ad hoc body, not a standing institution. It has no permanent staff, no threat assessment capability, and no pre-agreed protocols for the escalation sequence from supply monitoring to demand restraint to rationing.

The strategic reserve is thinner than it appears. NORA maintains 90 days of oil supply, meeting Ireland's IEA and EU obligations. Stocks are held at oil terminals across the island—Dublin, Cork (the former Whitegate refinery site), Whiddy Island in Bantry Bay, Foynes, Shannon, Tarbert, and Galway—as well as at Derry and Kilroot in Northern Ireland. However, 28 per cent of total stocks are held abroad in other EU member states under bilateral stockholding agreements. In a crisis affecting multiple EU states simultaneously—which is precisely the scenario the current conflict creates—the practical availability of those foreign-held stocks is uncertain.

Ireland has already committed 1.6 million barrels (approximately 10.5 days of supply) to the IEA's 400-million-barrel collective release. If the crisis extends beyond the summer, the reserve draws down further. And Ireland has no domestic refining capacity: the Whitegate refinery in Cork, the state's only refinery, ceased independent refining operations. Ireland imports finished fuel products—petrol, diesel, kerosene, jet fuel—meaning even with crude oil in reserve, the refining bottleneck remains. The reserve buys time; it does not resolve a supply disruption. And the time it buys is shrinking with every release.

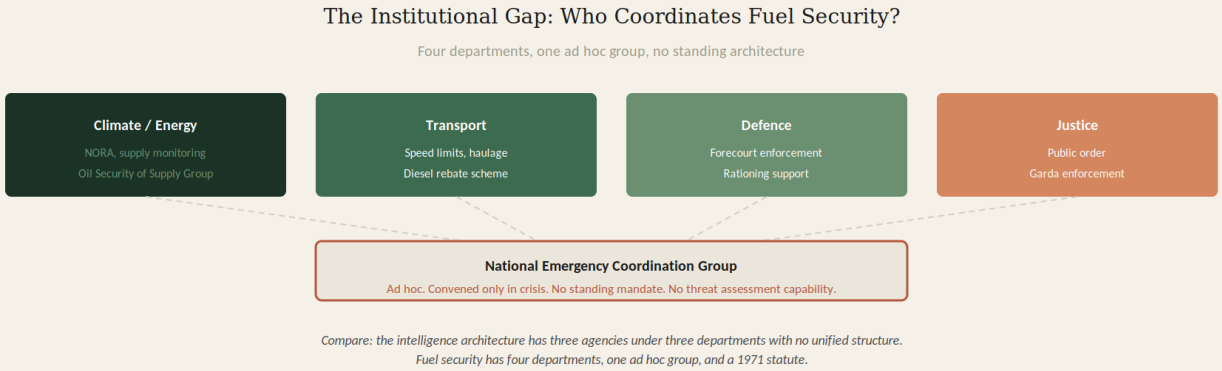

Figure 3: The institutional gap. Four departments, one ad hoc coordination group, no standing architecture. The fuel security fragmentation mirrors the intelligence architecture fragmentation.

The pattern: architectural absence as system design

The fuel crisis reveals the same pattern the foundational papers diagnose across every other security domain.

In December 2025, unidentified drones were detected during President Zelensky's visit. Portugal's GNR provided drone defence because Ireland could not. The institutional architecture for airspace security did not exist.

In March 2026, the government is stress-testing fuel rationing plans that put soldiers at petrol stations. The institutional architecture for fuel crisis management does not exist.

The pattern is identical. A state whose institutional system has been configured, over a century, for the absence of security capability reaches for coercive tools—military personnel, emergency powers, ministerial orders—when it encounters a threat its institutions were not designed to manage. This is not a failure of policy. It is the system working as designed: a system designed for the absence of capability produces exactly this outcome when capability is required.

The five domains analysed in the foundational papers—maritime approaches, airspace, subsea infrastructure, the energy grid, and cyber—describe the shared security envelope. Fuel supply is the sixth domain. It was omitted because the electricity grid (SEM, SONI/EirGrid) was treated as 'energy.' But fuel supply is a separate vulnerability with a separate supply chain, separate institutional architecture, and separate crisis dynamics. The current crisis makes the distinction impossible to ignore.

> ***A non-aligned state that understood its position correctly would have robust energy security infrastructure precisely because it cannot rely on alliance guarantees for supply protection. Ireland's fuel vulnerability is the energy corollary of its defence vulnerability—both products of the same century-old institutional logic.***

Six recommendations

These reforms can be initiated immediately, as none requires primary legislation to begin. All are independently valuable; if the crisis passes, the institutional infrastructure remains.

1. Establish a standing Energy Security Unit. Replace the ad hoc Oil Security of Supply Group with a permanent, staffed unit within the Department of Climate, Energy and the Environment. The unit should have standing authority to monitor supply chain risk, produce threat assessments integrating geopolitical analysis with supply data, maintain pre-agreed escalation protocols (from monitoring to demand restraint to allocation to rationing), and coordinate across departments without waiting for ministerial convening. The National Security Committee should receive the unit's threat assessments alongside IMIS, GNCSIS, and NCSC reporting. Fuel supply risk is a national security input, not just an energy policy input.

2. Repatriate strategic reserves. Accelerate the policy established in the 2015 Energy White Paper to hold the maximum feasible volume of Ireland's emergency stocks within Ireland. The current 72/28 split (domestic/abroad) is a peacetime optimisation. In a crisis affecting multiple EU states, stocks held in continental European storage facilities may not be practically accessible—either because the host state prioritises its own supply, because shipping routes are disrupted, or because the logistical chain for moving stored product to Ireland is slower than the crisis demands. The target should be 90 per cent domestic holding within three years, with investment in additional storage capacity at Dublin, Cork, Whiddy Island (Bantry Bay), Foynes, and Shannon. NORA's stocks at Derry and Kilroot in Northern Ireland should be formally integrated into the cross-border fuel coordination mechanism proposed in recommendation 4.

3. Modernise the legal framework. The 1971 Fuels (Control of Supplies) Act should be replaced with a modern Energy Security Act that addresses the current threat environment: hybrid disruption of shipping routes, cyber threats to fuel distribution infrastructure, cross-border supply coordination with Northern Ireland, and the integration of fuel security with the broader national security architecture. The 1971 Act gives the Minister power to 'take control of the supply and distribution of fuels'—a blunt instrument designed for an era of state-owned fuel companies applied to a liberalised, internationally integrated energy market with complex hedging practices, just-in-time distribution, and digital supply chain management. The new Act should establish the standing Energy Security Unit on a statutory basis, define the escalation sequence from monitoring to demand restraint to allocation to rationing with legal clarity, and provide for emergency procurement of fuel supply from alternative sources.

4. Add fuel supply to the North/South Implementation Protocol. The North/South Security Implementation Protocol identifies four cross-border coordination functions. Fuel supply should be the fifth. NORA already holds stocks in Derry and Kilroot in Northern Ireland. Cross-border fuel distribution operates through integrated supply chains. A fuel crisis in one jurisdiction propagates to the other. The SEM Committee coordinates the electricity grid cross-border; an equivalent coordination mechanism for fuel supply should be established through the same Strand Two infrastructure.

5. Integrate fuel security into the unified intelligence architecture. The Intelligence Architecture Reform paper proposes a National Security and Intelligence Agency (NSIA) that produces integrated threat assessments across all security domains. Fuel supply chain risk—shipping route disruption, chokepoint threats, refining capacity constraints, strategic reserve status—should be a standing input to the NSIA's threat picture. The current arrangement, in which NORA collates industry information and the Oil Security of Supply Group meets ad hoc, produces supply data but not threat assessment. The difference matters: supply data tells you how much fuel is in storage; threat assessment tells you whether it will still be there next month.

6. Accelerate the Strategic Gas Emergency Reserve. The FSRU approved in March 2025 should be treated as a national security priority, not an energy policy project. Corrib gas production is expected to cease by 2027. When it does, Ireland will be 100 per cent dependent on two subsea interconnectors from Scotland for the gas that generates half its electricity and heats 650,000 homes. Ireland is the only EU member state without gas storage. The FSRU provides a partial answer—but only if it is operational before Corrib depletes. The procurement and deployment timeline should be compressed, and the FSRU's location (Shannon Estuary or Cork Harbour) should be decided by mid-2026. In parallel, the government should commission a gas security assessment examining the vulnerability of the two interconnectors to hybrid disruption—sabotage, cyber attack, or physical damage—of the kind the Nord Stream incident demonstrated is not hypothetical.

The government's €250 million package addresses the immediate price impact. The excise cuts, the haulage rebate, and the fuel allowance extension are the correct short-term responses. But they are demand-side measures for a supply-side problem. If the crisis extends—if the Strait of Hormuz remains disrupted, if Bab el-Mandeb closes, if the war in Iran escalates further—Ireland will need institutional architecture that does not currently exist.

The Presidency begins in July. Ireland will chair Council discussions on energy security, critical infrastructure resilience, and defence coordination. The credibility of Ireland's position in those discussions depends on whether it has built the domestic institutional infrastructure that its geographic vulnerability demands. Soldiers at petrol stations is not an energy security strategy. It is the absence of one.

> ***The state that has no radar, no armed patrol vessels, and no unified intelligence is now considering putting soldiers at petrol stations. The pattern is the same in every domain: a system designed for the absence of capability produces exactly this outcome when capability is required.***

WHY THIS MATTERS NOW

The fuel crisis is live. The government is stress-testing rationing contingency plans. The Presidency begins in three months. The five recommendations in this note can be initiated immediately—the standing Energy Security Unit by administrative decision, the reserve repatriation by policy directive, the North/South fuel coordination through the existing Protocol framework. The legal modernisation and intelligence integration require legislation but should be

initiated now. The crisis creates the political window for institutional reform that would be impossible to achieve in peacetime. That window should not be wasted on excise cuts alone.

SERIES CONTEXT

This note extends the Security Ireland analytical suite by identifying fuel supply as the sixth security domain. It connects to the *UK–Ireland Security Interface* (the shared domain now includes fuel supply vulnerability), the *North/South Security Implementation Protocol* (fuel coordination as the fifth cross-border function), the *Intelligence Architecture Reform paper* (supply chain threat assessment as NSIA input), and the *Neutrality as Institutional Architecture* paper (fuel dependency as the energy corollary of defence dependency). The five-domain framework in the foundational papers should be updated to six.

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